

Adult Learning Design Report

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Course: ITLS 6720

Section 1: Scenario Overview

- **Title:** Conducting Empathetic User Interviews: Bridging Technical Design and Human Experience
- **Organizational Context:** Learning occurs within a software engineering group or tech company, utilizing a blended approach (asynchronous digital modules followed by a face-to-face workshop in a collaborative conference space).
- **Target Audience:** Mid-level software developers and junior designers (ages 22–45?). These are highly analytical professionals who excel in technical execution but lack formal training in human-centered communication.
- **Learning Need:** A performance gap exists during user testing and feedback cycles. Developers are accustomed to the objective, binary nature of code. When faced with subjective human feedback, they often struggle with empathy, ask leading questions, or become defensive, which bottlenecks the growth process.
- **Desired Future State:** Developers will confidently navigate subjective user feedback, utilizing active listening and emotional regulation to gather unbiased, actionable data that improves software iterations.
- **Learning Goal:** Equip technical professionals with the human-centered communication frameworks necessary to conduct unbiased user testing and process critical feedback constructively.
- **Learning Objectives:**
 1. **Construct Unbiased Questions:** Learners will draft and utilize open-ended questions that allow users to speak authentically about their experience with the software.
 2. **Apply Active Listening:** Learners will demonstrate active listening techniques (summarizing, mirroring) during mock interviews to establish psychological safety for the user.

3. **Manage Personal Defensiveness:** Learners will identify their own defensive triggers and utilize emotional regulation techniques when receiving critical feedback on their designs or code.

Section 2: Adult Learner Analysis

To effectively design for this population, we must look beyond their technical capabilities and understand their cognitive controls and personal situation.

Profile: The Analytical Creator

- **Individual Differences:**

- Cognitive controls: Generally, these learners are analytical, detail-oriented, and hate uncertainty. However, individuals will vary in their tolerance for ambiguity; some will demand clear, black-and-white instructions for every step, while others will adapt more easily to the fluid nature of human feedback.
- Personality: Some may take immense pride in their work. Consequently, their frustration tolerance can drop significantly when non-technical users misinterpret or criticize a feature they spent weeks building. Different personalities may do better or worse with constructive criticism, their confidence, or emotional intelligence.
- Prior Knowledge: One developer might have read a few articles on UX/UI design and has a little bit of background knowledge or social experience, while another developer might have absolutely zero exposure to it.

- **Situational Differences:**

- *Time Constraints & Workload:* They operate in high-stress, fast-paced sprint cycles. Time-limited, and mandatory training is often viewed as a disruption to their workload.
- *Organizational Culture:* Tech environments heavily reward hard skills and deployment speed, often undervaluing soft skills.

- **Subject-Matter Differences:**

- *Perceived Difficulty:* The difficulty lies not in cognitive complexity, but in emotional vulnerability. Translating fluid human emotions into the rigid, rule-based world they are comfortable in is difficult and a big shift. As simple as the subject can seem, it is much harder to apply and truly understand.

Section 3: Andragogy Principles Analysis

Principle	Status	Evidence / Risk	Design Response & Innovation Opportunity
1. Need to Know	Vulnerable	Risk: Because soft skills contrast with their daily coding tasks, they may view this as irrelevant HR "fluff."	Response: Anchor the training in Return On Investment. Show how better interviews reduce costly rework and bug fixes.
2. Self-Concept	Threatened	Risk: Participation is mandatory, which immediately threatens adult autonomy and can breed resentment.	Response: Provide autonomy in the materials. Learners select the specific project and past feedback they use for their roleplay scenarios.
3. Prior Experience	Mixed	Risk: Their prior experience is highly technical; they may feel out of their depth in a soft-skills workshop.	Response: Use their actual technical builds (like a recent interface deployment or a current Figma wireframe) as the focal point of the communication exercises.

Principle	Status	Evidence / Risk	Design Response & Innovation Opportunity
4. Readiness to Learn (timing and relevance)	Strong	Evidence: They constantly face user feedback during sprint reviews, making the application immediate.	Innovation: Align the face-to-face workshop directly with the end of a sprint cycle when user testing is top-of-mind, recent and applicable.
5. Orientation (applicable, problem-centered)	Strong	Evidence: Developers are natural problem solvers.	Innovation: Frame the subjective nature of human emotions as a system to be debugged using specific communication frameworks.
6. Motivation	Vulnerable	Risk: Intrinsic motivation for soft skills is low in tech-heavy roles.	Response: Highlight how mastering these skills leads to career advancement, team leadership opportunities, and less personal frustration.

Section 4: Adult Learning Process Model

Need

- **The Gap:** Developers build functional tools but fail to gather accurate usability data because they guide the user or defend the design during testing.
- **Vulnerability:** The "Need to Know" is highly vulnerable here. To help learners recognize the need, the pre-training survey asks them to reflect on a specific time

when user feedback frustrated them, surfacing the pain point before the training even begins.

Create

- **Instructional Approach:** Experiential Learning & Roleplay. This approach honors the adult need for problem-centered, practical application. Moving away from traditional lectures, this design relies on Neuroandragogy, specifically creating an enriched environment. By blending visual models (async videos), peer collaboration, and tangible material (their own code/wireframes), we increase the likelihood of new neuronal networks forming.
- **Design Rationale:** Abstract emotional concepts must be translated into actionable protocols (e.g., a 3-step checklist for responding to criticism) through these Experiential Learning & Roleplay sessions to align with the learners' analytical cognitive style.

Implement

- **Delivery Modality:** Blended.
- **Progression:**
 1. *Exploration (Asynchronous):* Learners control the pace of foundational videos, reducing extra cognitive load.
 2. *Application (F2F):* Learners bring their own projects into breakout rooms for the mock interviews, distributing the cognitive load with the collective working memory effect.
- **Strengthened Principles:** Prior experience is really strengthened by forcing learners to practice empathetic communication while looking at the exact project that previously caused them stress.

Evaluate

- **Demonstrate Learning:** Traditional testing is not used. Instead, learners demonstrate competency through the active execution of the roleplay and given feedback.
- **Assessment (Self-Explanation):** After each round, learners use a digital workbook to pause, reflect, and summarize where the communication broke down and how to pivot, mirroring the iterative process of software development and showing us what they truly learned and experienced first-hand.

- **Impact Tracking- Quality of Insights:** Long-term evaluation will look at the type of data developers bring back to the team. Success will be measured by an increase in deep, actionable design insights gathered from users, rather than basic reports. We can schedule a follow-up mock interview down the line to see their progress as well.

Section 5: Learning Scenario Blueprint

Session Title: Debugging the Human Interface: Empathetic User Interviews

Purpose: To transform how technical staff receive and process subjective user feedback.

Time Needed: 1 Hour (Async pre-work) + 2 Hours (F2F Workshop)

AL Principles Addressed: Prior Experience, Problem-Centered Orientation, Need to Know

Phase	Learning Strategy	Learner Actions	Facilitator Actions
Pre-Work (Async)	Needs Assessment & Priming Honors autonomy and prior experience.	Completes anonymous survey identifying a specific piece of frustrating user feedback. Reviews short, chunked videos on active listening.	Reviews survey data to curate the F2F roleplay groupings based on shared project frustrations.
Opener (F2F, 15 min)	Establishing the "Need to Know" Tying soft skills to hard metrics.	Engages in a brief discussion on how poor feedback leads to development rework.	Presents a high-impact case study showing time saved through unbiased interviewing.

Phase	Learning Strategy	Learner Actions	Facilitator Actions
Activity 1 (F2F, 30 min)	Collaborative Problem Solving Using real-world artifacts.	Breaks into pairs. Learner A brings up their own wireframe/project. Learner B acts as the "confused user." Learner A practices open-ended questioning.	Floats between breakout rooms, providing micro-corrections and ensuring psychological safety.
Reflection (F2F, 15 min)	Self-Explanation Effect Cognitive processing and encoding.	Opens digital workbook. Writes a brief summary identifying their own defensive triggers encountered during the mock interview. What worked what didn't.	Provides a structured digital workbook with clear, analytical prompts.
Activity 2 (F2F, 30 min)	Role Reversal & Application Reinforcing the neuronal network.	Swaps roles. Learner A now acts as the user, experiencing the feedback loop from the other side.	Monitors time constraints and ensures feedback remains constructive.
Closing (F2F, 15 min)	Action Planning	Commits to one specific listening framework to use in the upcoming Friday sprint review.	Summarizes key takeaways. Bridges the workshop concepts directly to

Phase	Learning Strategy	Learner Actions	Facilitator Actions
	Readiness to learn and immediate application.		the organization's upcoming project deadlines. This applies it well to the team's work.

Innovation Element:

Getting out of the typical pedagogical practices, this module uses real, not hypothetical, case studies. By requiring developers to use their own active development builds during the roleplay, the training acts as a dual-purpose session: they learn soft skills while advancing actual organizational projects, entirely eliminating the busy work perception.